

'This must not end here!' – The Club

Caroline Wessel

In May 1860, a group of gentlemen, though 'differing greatly in character and opinions', enjoyed a friendly supper party after one of them had delivered a 'Lit and Phil' lecture. 'Various exciting subjects were discussed with the greatest freedom, but with perfect good temper,' and as the evening drew to a close someone declared 'This must not end here!' These immortal words became the group's motto and were later engraved on the fine and intricately-worked silver Loving Cup of 'The Club'. Its members met regularly in their different homes for the next fifty years, indulging in sumptuous food – 'grateful stimuli to philosophical palates' excellent and rare wines, and 'the spirit of generous and noble friendship'.



The Club Cup, 'we all stand registered on our Cup, side by side, enshrined in everlasting silver' (Reproduced by permission of Leicester Museums and Galleries).

The Club had its structure and rules: the keeping and unanimous passing of Minutes in the Record Book, the Loving Cup toast, the composing of Club Poems, the start time of meetings, the modesty of supper menus, the approval of invited guests – and the eternal membership of The Club, 'even unto old age and death'. However, the strictest rule was that 'the utmost freedom should be given to the

expression of opinion, and there should be no limit other than that prescribed by good taste'. Club members should be controversial and unprejudiced, 'diverse or antagonistic in theological and political views', yet 'Club friendship was proof against all outdoor quarrels'. The Club motto 'This Must Not End Here!' would ensure that at each meeting, another must follow – *ad infinitum*.

So who were these 'queer old fogies', as The Club Poet humorously described them?

Charles Caillard (1805-1873), the oldest Club member and a Lit. and Phil. President, was a French chevalier and refugee from Paris, who could remember Waterloo, fought on the barricades of Paris in 1830, fled to England for liberty, and settled in Leicester as Professor of Modern Languages. He was the first to suggest lady members of the Lit. & Phil. and was 'the brave defender of all social liberties and the unfailing advocate of all that was artistic, tasteful and refined.' He took up the idea of The Club and hosted its inaugural meeting.



Caillard, French refugee and Languages Professor, and 'the brave defender of all liberties'. (Reproduced by permission of the Leicester Literary and Philosophical Society).

Edwin Clephan (1817-1906), from Stockton-on-Tees, was manager (later partner) of Paget's Bank on High Street. A staunch Liberal, he was also a magistrate, President of the Leicester School of Arts, director of Leicester Waterworks, and the Club's historian. Members admired his fine collection of watercolour paintings and the novel and elegant wall-coverings of his 'mansion' at 92 Regent Road (later the

St John Ambulance HQ). His daughter, Mary, married the artist, George Elgood.

William Billson (1830-1901), solicitor and Borough Treasurer, was a native of Leicester and his home on the corner of De Montfort Square boasted a well-chosen and well-bound library.

The dark-haired *George Franklin (1815-1893)* came from Coventry to Leicester in 1845 to be a master at the Proprietary School (now New Walk Museum). From there, he started up his own successful Stoneygate School. Of Liberal politics, he was a Lit. and Phil. President, a published writer, and an artist as well as a scholar. The 'little gems of art upon his walls' included watercolours by the renowned artist, David Cox.

Revd Charles Coe (1830-1921), was Minister of the Great Meeting Chapel in Bond Street, whose influential Unitarian congregation (including several members of the Club), wielded a strong Radical influence on the political affairs of the town. A published writer and Lit. and Phil. President, Coe moved away to minister in Bolton, but was the last surviving member of The Club. Still living in 1909, he deposited its Record Book and Cup for safe keeping at the Leicester Museum.



Coe, Unitarian minister and last surviving member of The Club. (Reproduced by permission of the Leicester Literary and Philosophical Society).

Another clerical member of The Club was *John Picton (1821-1882)*, Anglican Rector of Desford, whose church he allowed to fall into deplorable disrepair. Ordained in 1848, and educated at Dublin University, he certainly had the gift of the gab, acquiring a reputation within The Club for his long, rambling, but highly entertaining anecdotes about famous personages known to him, in preference to philosophy or argument – 'the Rector being with us,

anecdote reigned supreme.' Forgetful too, it seems, for 'Picton, though expected, neither turned up nor wrote, according to his usual practice.'

Frederick Mott (1825-1908), prosperous wine merchant with royal patronage. A Borough Councillor, supporter of a Museum and Free Library for Leicester, Lit. and Phil. President, published writer, Fellow of the Royal Geographical Society, Liberal and free-thinker, Mott was the acknowledged rebel of The Club. Described alternatively as pugnacious, a firebrand, argumentative and eccentric, he delighted in stirring up fiery arguments at every turn. He controversially wore a beard and even published a paper (1855) defending beards. A great country-lover, he led The Club's excursions to Charnwood, his place at Benscliff, and his country cottage at Birstall.



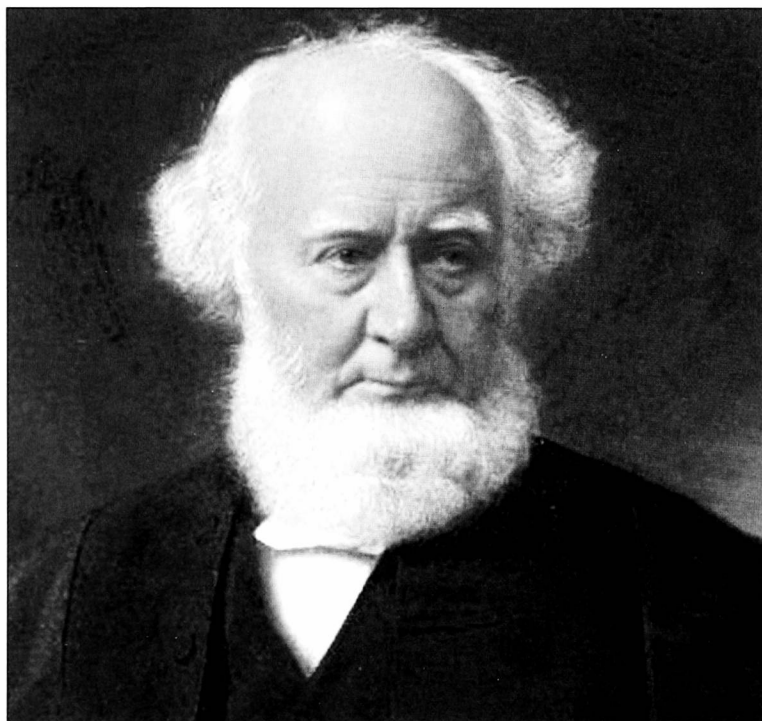
Mott, wine merchant, who 'maintained the right of The Club not to be enslaved by inconvenient etiquette'. (Reproduced by permission of the Leicester Literary and Philosophical Society).



Stevenson, solicitor, with 'genial face and fine countenance'. (Reproduced by permission of the Leicester Literary and Philosophical Society).

George Stevenson (1820-1904), solicitor and magistrate, was a Lit. and Phil. President, Mayor in 1869, and a published writer and art collector. Due to his persistent efforts the Leicester Free Library was established in 1871. The same year he resigned as Alderman over the controversial siting of the new Town Hall, but was soon re-elected. It was at his supper in De Montfort Square that the idea of The Club was first mooted.

William Napier Reeve (1811-1888), 'our white-haired patriarch, the smallest amongst us in body, but perhaps the largest in heart and brain', was a solicitor, Clerk of the Peace, Clerk to the Lunatic Asylum, Lit. and Phil. President, and also a prolific author under the pseudonym 'Eliot Roscoe'. A venerable and eloquent host at Club meetings, his lavish suppers frequently exceeded the regulation modesty dictated by Club rules.



Reeve, solicitor, 'a brave spirit and generous heart', 'crowned with patriarchal snows'. (Reproduced by permission of the Leicester Literary and Philosophical Society).

John Williams (1818-1899), sharebroker and accountant was also a magistrate and Secretary to the Water Works Company. Born in Denmark though of pure British blood, he distinguished himself at the Abbey Park Opening, by conversing fluently in Danish with the Danish Princess of Wales. Club members admired his drawing room, conservatory and fine library of books, and were kept in a state of delight and admiration by his bursts of eloquence.

George Toller (1815-1885), solicitor, was three times Mayor, and like Stevenson, became embroiled in disagreements over the site for the new Town Hall. A popular figure, in 1872 he was appointed Town Clerk, but after six weeks found the strain too much and resigned through ill-health. The large family home stood on land that is now Toller Road.

Arthur Paget (1848-1909), was from a leading Leicester family. A successful architect with prizes from London's University College, he joined the Goddard architectural practice in 1873. A Liberal and Unitarian at the Great Meeting, he was something of a Shakespearean scholar. One of his Papers was a fascinating attempt to reconstruct Shakespeare's theatre buildings from contemporary stage instructions. His own firm designed his spacious home on West Walk, where he lived with his wife, Clephan's daughter, Jane.

James Hollings (1806-1862), schoolmaster, Mayor, magistrate, three times Lit. and Phil. President, writer and historian, stands as the figurehead of The Club. For it was he who rose at that very first informal supper, and with characteristic enthusiasm exclaimed 'Stevenson, this must not end here.' His words were engraved on the lip of the Cup, but he did not live to see it, for he died tragically soon afterwards at the house of his brother-in-law, John Biggs, prominent citizen of Leicester. Head of the Leicester Proprietary School, his main subjects were Science and Latin, but he wrote prolifically on the town's history, including a definitive Paper on the Civil War in Leicester. A fine memorial to Hollings used to stand close to the Museum. Its Latin inscription was composed by Franklin and most of The Club were on the committee supervising its erection. Hollings reputedly had 'the heart of a woman and the brain of an encyclopaedia, learned on all points but unable to say no', and was remembered for his genial heart, kindly temper, universal knowledge, and fluent and cheerful conversation.



Hollings, schoolmaster, 'a genial heart, a kindly temper and universal knowledge'. (Reproduced by permission of the Leicester Literary and Philosophical Society).

The Club Minute Book (1) miraculously enables us to eavesdrop on all its conversations. As 'flies on the wall' we overhear heated points of view on a wide range of

contemporary issues. Naturally, there is much discussion on the town of Leicester, and its personalities. The new tower of St Martin's church is both praised and called 'commonplace'; the agitated question of the demolition of the Cattle Market as a site for the new Town Hall rumbles on; the location of the new Leicester Barracks at Glen Parva is announced; and all agree that the new Alderman Newton School in St Martin's is 'one of the best examples of architecture' in town.

The new Leicestershire Club in Welford Place, 'in the agonies of birth' and with £4,500-worth of shares already subscribed by prosperous town businessmen, is challenging Market Street's County Club, bastion of the landed gentry. And the General News Room, formerly a leading institution, is 'at the doors of death', as 'the clubs are killing it'. There is fear of a mistake in purchasing Gas Works shares, because of the coming electricity; and Toller's cab is hit by two horses broken loose from the Tram-car. The Art Gallery has just spent £500 on De Wint's painting of *Lincoln*; but should the remaining £1,500 in the fund be spent on two or three great paintings, or a greater number of works each costing less?



Hollings Memorial, formerly outside New Walk Museum. (Reproduced by permission of the Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicester and Rutland, location mark DE3736 Box24).

We mix freely with The Club's wider circle of friends. We learn of Herr Ptacek's Grand Concert at Temperance Hall, and hear chat of 'our old friend' (artist) Mr Flower. Chairman of the Railway Company, Mr John Ellis' character is defended; Benjamin Broadbent has given at his own expense the Bow Bridge carved stone commemorating the death of Richard III; and Dr Noble of Dannet's Hall, with his remarkable intuitive powers of diagnosis, dies of cholera, alone in Malaga. However the two prominent citizens who come in for the most animated comment are Robert Hall and John Biggs. Hall, 'that great wise ugly man' and 'mighty hero of Leicester Nonconformists', excites both esteem and dislike. Toller admires Hall's 'powerful many-worded full-sounding Johnsonian eloquence'; but Reeve considers his

sermons 'so long and tedious', whilst Billson 'is weary of that great white figure before his window', and wishes the 'ugly statue' in De Montfort Square down. Leicester manufacturer and MP, John Biggs, was apparently known in the House of Commons as 'Marshall Biggs', from his style of dress and bluff jovial manner. He is blamed by Club members for the untimely and tragic death of his brother-in-law, their beloved Hollings.

National figures of importance also populate the Minute Book pages (Cardinal) Newman the Romanist is considered 'the greatest intellect of the day'; Ellen Terry, seen in the flesh, is 'piquante but scarcely beautiful'; atheist Charles Bradlaugh and Mrs Annie Besant teach disgusting doctrines about population control; and D'Israeli, though a slippery character and hard drinker, taking four or five glasses of brandy before speaking in the House, 'sends women wild'. A report 'that the Queen is growing dull-witted and stupid', and calls Gladstone 'the enemy' is not to be believed. The Prince of Wales, though incurring gambling debts at Melton Mowbray, is a good husband, father and master. He frequently sends for the pianist Charles Hallé, with whom he enjoys many hours of delightful music and conversation.

Art and literature are discussed at length. Turner's latest painting, being unintelligible is useless as a picture, and artist Holman Hunt, about to marry a relation of Reeve's, started his career in such poverty that at times he had to remain in bed all day for lack of coals. Caillard maintains that *Pilgrim's Progress* is 'a foolish and merely sectarian book' and Reeve considers *Paradise Lost* to be 'so dull, so heavy, so lengthy'. Mott calls Byron's *Don Juan* 'devilish' and Fielding's *Tom Jones* 'very obscene'. But all agree that Tennyson's *In Memoriam* is the finest of all modern poems.

Religion continuously provokes deep thought and outspoken word, and a change in theological views by all churches during the previous fifty years is noted. The brave question, 'Is the history of Christ truth or fiction?' is posed. The Episcopalians, Roman Catholics, Broad Church, Positivists and Salvation Army are all considered, though Reeve believes that the worship of the antique Jupiter is shortly to be revived! A schism at St Martin's church is reported, whereby the Ritualists stand when the vicar passes down the aisle, but the Rationalists rigidly sit in their places. And Reverend Hopps holds 4,000 people spellbound at the Floral Hall, where he proclaims on the true meaning of Faith.

A remarkable 'modern-ness' abounds in these lives of 140 years ago. Fox-hunting is considered cruel; homeopathy is both admired and derided; punishment for criminals should be reformatory as well as deterrent, and capital punishment is questionable; the dilemma of euthanasia cannot be solved; competitive exams keep clever boys back because of

cramming; anxiety is the chief destroyer of health – and dentists in America have invented a way of filling teeth with gold leaf!

The gossip, weather, fashion, wit and colloquialisms recorded in the Minute Book transport us directly into the everyday Victorian middle-class world. The wealthy Mr

Thomas Paget is to marry Miss Stratton, even though he is sixty and she just twenty-five, but it is considered 'quite justifiable for the purpose of procuring an heir to his wealth.' The prolonged eight-week period of below freezing temperatures and four inches of snow during 1878/9 causes many accidents, and throws builders and gardeners out of work.

THE CLUB AT BENSCLIFF.

JULY 31, 1873.

There's no more inspiration, old Castaly's dried up ;
There's nothing but a julep left to fill our empty cup ;
For Reeve's away, and Caillard lies paralyzed and sick,
And even the jolly Rector's gone lame and rheumatic.

Toller grows portly, Williams shows horizontal creases,
Billson gets stout, and Stevenson decidedly obese is,
Franklin's dark locks are grizzling fast, Clephan's are worse for wear,
Coe's growing lazy, dull old Mott's as stupid as a bear.

A Club worn out and blasé ! what holds us still together ?
Why don't we scatter like a heap of dust in windy weather ?
Eleven queer old fogies pretending to be funny !
Best give it up, and stay at home, and grub all day for money.

Ah, well ! the world's a riddle, and man has many moods,
And though we're fat and fifty, we love the green old woods,
There's something in the sloping hills and lichen-crustled crags
That's medicine for an ancient soul, and stirs it when it flags.

We won't pretend to fathom the subtle ways and means
By which our grim philosophy's all blown to smithereens,
We don't know how it is, nor why, nor what's the *raison d'être*,
We only know that *beans is beans, and cabbage is 'nt 'tater*.

That stout, and stiff, and stupid, we still have hearts and brains ;
That thirteen years of friendship bind us fast like brazen chains ;
That Castaly and Helicon may turn to dust and rags,
But the Club and the Cup at Benscliff shall meet while the old world wags !

F. T. MOTT.

The new male fashion of wearing beards is popular amongst junior clerks, but older legal men still shave. White tie with tails for gentlemen at dinner is sometimes now replaced by black tie. And a fashionable Leicester dinner party comprises seven courses and dessert with half a dozen different wines. Wit is ever present and anecdotes, riddles, conundrums and spelling tests spice the verbal exchange. But most of all, colloquial speech patterns enable us to 'hear' the very dialogue – 'Mr Reeve being thus put to a non plus and obliged to speak out', or 'there was a curious contrariety of opinion', or 'supper was specialized by a rich confection.'



Reeve's house, Prebend Street, venue of sumptuous suppers, though criticized by the Stoics as too lavish.

In fact, food and drink is of near-obsessive interest throughout the Minute Book, as the Stoics continuously argue The Club rule with the Epicureans, contesting the lavishness and ostentation of a meal. Stevenson's table is

'sumptuously loaded with cold turkey, beef and tongue and a profusion of luxuries. A growl from Billson who warned this was irregular, but even philosophers are amenable to appetite...we fell to'. Every supper menu is listed, and we read of oyster patties, stewed eels, lobster cutlets, salmon mayonnaise, saddle of mutton, roasted fowls, jugged hare and pigeon pie, with desserts of cranberry tart, blanc-mange, jelly, pineapple creams, Topsy Cake, Bachelor's Pudding, hot-house grapes, or macaroni and cheese, and all washed down by Hock, Claret, Burgundy, Sherry, or a rare and luxurious Port 'which bore in its heart the wonderful sunlight of that famous autumn of 1834'.

But the ritual of The Club Cup – 'the symbol and banner of life' is the highlight of every gathering. Its contents vary from a summertime bumper of champagne, iced Claret, sparkling Muscatelle or iced Hock-julep, to a winter beverage of hot milk punch, mulled Claret, mulled Hermitage, Whisky Curacao, or 'a liquor so warm and rich and fascinating that an encore was called for and freely given.' The Cup is housed in a box of wood taken from a pillar of the old Leicester Castle – oak felled 700 years ago, 700 years growing before felled, so timber 1300 years old and – 'to us a symbol of endurance, courage and patriotism'. It is these three admirable qualities that bind together this extraordinary fraternity of intelligent, successful, but above all innovative, dissenting and enquiring gentlemen, in an age of expanding thought, philosophy, belief and inventiveness. Truly, The Club – as reflected in its 'behind-the-scenes' Minute Book – is a fascinating and enlightening insight into a vibrant Victorian world.

Notes and References:

'The Club' is not to be confused with the Leicestershire Club, a separate and much larger organisation.

The Club Cup is housed at New Walk Museum, Leicester, and can be viewed by appointment only.

1. Minute Book of 'The Club'. Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicester and Rutland: 112/09.



The Club Cup, close-up of the Club motto 'This Must Not End Here' (Reproduced by permission of Leicester Museums and Galleries).